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****Quick Bridge:**** You have been talking to your manager about your career goals in every one-on-one. You are doing the right thing. But your manager is only one voice in the room when your name comes up for a leadership role. This post explains who the actual decision-makers are, why your manager may not be carrying your case, and what you can do this week to make sure the right people know what you want. Your career is too important to depend on one advocate who may not be making your case.

Your Manager Isn't the Only One Deciding Your Promotion

For months, every one-on-one with my manager included the same conversation. I wanted to move from senior individual contributor into management, and I wanted to know what I could do to make that happen. I thought I was handling it right.

Then I got two job offers. One from another department inside the company. One from outside. Neither felt like the right fit, but getting them forced a conversation I did not expect.

My manager asked me to talk to his boss and their boss before I made any decision. I sat down expecting a pep talk. What I got was a shock.

My manager's boss had no idea I wanted to move into leadership. None. My manager had been quietly putting me in for a promotion to principal instead, because he did not want to lose me as an IC.

I was not angry at him. He needed a strong senior individual contributor on his team and I was one.

But in that moment I realized something I had completely missed. ****My manager was not the only person making decisions about my career. And he was the only person who knew what I wanted.****

The advice everyone gives you is right, and incomplete

You have been told to talk to your manager. Tell them your goals. Be clear about what you want. That advice is correct.

It is also incomplete in a way that matters.

Your manager is one input in the promotion process, not the final word. At most companies, their boss has to approve leadership moves. The peers of your manager often weigh in informally. Cross-functional leaders who have worked with you carry their own impressions into rooms you never enter.

If none of those people know your goals, you are depending entirely on your manager to make your case. And your manager has their own priorities.

They need their team covered. They need their projects staffed. Moving their best individual contributor into management creates a gap they have to fill on a timeline that does not always work for them.

They are not trying to hurt you. They are doing what their job requires them to do. But those two things can work against you at the same time, without anyone realizing it.

What actually happens when a leadership role opens up

The conversation happens in a room you are not in.

Your manager shares their perspective. Their boss asks who they see as ready. Their peers might name someone they have noticed in cross-functional work. A skip-level leader asks if anyone has expressed interest in stepping up.

****If your name has only come from your manager, you have one advocate.**** If your manager has not been making the case, or has been steering the conversation toward your future as a senior individual contributor, you are entering that discussion at a disadvantage you did not know existed.

The information gap existed because I assumed telling one person was enough.

He did not carry my goals the way I had shared them. He carried his own version. That version left out the part where I wanted to lead.

Fill in the gaps yourself

This does not mean going around your manager. It means deciding to share your goals with the people who also have a say.

****Have the conversation with your skip-level.**** Asking for 30 minutes to connect is reason enough. Be direct about why you are there: "I have been building toward a leadership move and I wanted to make sure you had a sense of where I am headed." That gives them information they can carry forward.

****Be visible in cross-functional work.**** Every project that involves other departments is a chance to be known by people who are not your manager. Showing up and doing good work in rooms where your manager is not the only one watching is enough.

****Say your goals plainly when the opportunity is there.**** You do not need to announce your ambitions in a group meeting. When a senior leader asks where you see yourself going, say it clearly: "I am interested in moving into a leadership role over the next year or two." Most leaders, if they think you are ready, will do something with that information.

Your manager is an important part of your path. They are not the whole path. ****The people making decisions about your future need to hear from you directly, not just through the person they already know.****

Why the three offers mattered

Getting those external offers did not get me promoted. They exposed the gap. They forced a conversation that should have happened months earlier.

The external interviews created urgency that my one-on-one conversations had not. My manager's boss needed to hear my goals from me. I had been outsourcing that responsibility without realizing it.

You do not need external offers to have that conversation. You can have it now.

The only thing the offers did was give me a reason that was hard to ignore. That reason already exists. It is your career.

The action this week

Think about the people above your manager who have any say in how your career moves. If your manager left tomorrow, would anyone in senior leadership know what you want?

If the answer is no, that is the gap to fill. Start with one conversation.

Ask your manager's boss for 30 minutes. Tell them you wanted to connect and share where you are hoping to grow. That is a conversation you can choose to have this week.

Who in your organization, above your direct manager, knows exactly what you want from your career?

You're great at the work. Let's make you impossible to ignore.

If you are looking for help building visibility in your organization and advancing your career on your own terms, consider reaching out. jessestaffordcoaching.com

Tags: Leadership, Management, Career Advice, Engineering Management, Professional Development

Feature image prompt: A confident professional standing in a modern office hallway, facing toward a glass-walled conference room where three senior leaders are visibly seated in conversation. The lighting uses deep brand blue (#100299) tones. The shot is from behind the professional, emphasizing the distance between them and the decision-makers. Clean, minimal, no text overlays. Professional photography style.